

ROOKIE — The Early Career Platform for Students

As students, we all know roughly the same twenty companies. The firms with large advertising budgets, prestigious brand names, and hundreds of applications per position. They are visible. They are loud. And they dominate the conversation.

But what about the rest? The boutique firms, the SMEs, the specialist agencies that need skilled people just as much — if not more. They exist everywhere, they hire constantly, and most students never find them. Not because the opportunity is not there, but because nobody made it visible.

It is not a jobs problem. It is a visibility and matchmaking problem. The opportunities exist. The talent exists. They simply never find each other efficiently. Creating more jobs is difficult. Empowering the ones that already exist is compulsory.

The System is Broken

Companies built ATS systems that scan CVs for keywords. Students responded with AI-rewritten CVs, keyword insertion, the same sentence rephrased ten times to pass the filter. At this point, employment often comes down to whether the company's AI likes your AI. The actual human fit gets lost entirely.

The conventional approach failed because both sides work independently, with incomplete information, guessing what the other wants. That is where Rookie steps in — we give both parties a structured space to input who they are and what they need, and we take care of the translation. Everyone does what they are good at.

And when matching is done right, professional success stops being a privilege reserved for those with the highest grades or membership in three investment clubs. Talent is distributed far more evenly than opportunity currently is.

The Platform

For students: A professional profile beyond a CV — education, experience, skills, availability and preferences — making them discoverable by the right employers at the right time. No more spray-applying to everything. Targeted opportunities, direct outreach.

For companies: Direct access to verified student talent. Post structured listings, browse profiles filtered by degree, field and skills. No more scanning three hundred CVs in seconds hoping the right person is near the top. We take care of that pile.

For universities: Real-time visibility into student career activity and employer demand — uniquely valuable for curriculum design, career services and institutional reputation.

The Vision

Rookie is not another platform hoping to find its niche. The direction is one: to become the standard. The place every student opens when looking for an internship or first role. The community where companies find the best emerging talent. The infrastructure universities embed as naturally as a library. Not one of many options — the default.

That future is built one university at a time. Tilburg is where it starts.

What Comes Next

What you see today is Phase 1. Coming next: econometric and optimization-based matchmaking — mathematically rigorous models, not keyword filters. A marketplace for student-oriented events. Career intelligence tools for universities, and many more.

Built by a multidisciplinary team: an econometrician asking how mathematics can solve the placement problem; a computer scientist deploying AI where it creates real value — not to join the chorus of “revolutionary AI startups”, but to use it precisely and purposefully.

The Ask - Future

The ask from Tilburg University at this stage is focused and concrete. We are not asking for funding. We are asking for partnership.

Co-branding. The Tilburg University logo and name featured on Rookie — as the founding university partner. The first institution in what will become a network of universities across the Netherlands.

Active promotion. Rookie promoted to students as a facility — through orientation week communications, the TiU careers website, career services newsletters, and the student portal. The moment students arrive at TiU, they should know Rookie exists.

University login. Students able to sign in with their TiU institutional email — redirecting through the university's own authentication — so that access feels native, trusted, and frictionless.

A point of contact. A named person within TiU career services or faculty coordination who can champion the platform internally and keep communication open as we grow.

In return, Tilburg University becomes the founding university partner of a platform with national ambitions. TiU students get early access to the best version of Rookie, before it scales. The university gains real-time visibility into the career activity of its students and the skills employers are actually searching for. And TiU's name sits at the top of a platform that, in time, every student in the Netherlands will know.

This is the ground floor. And we are offering TiU the first seat.

We are not building hype.

We are optimizing the most important transition in a Rookie's life.

Curious?